

Cursorius rufus

Burchell's courser



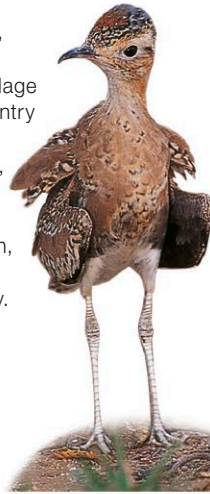
Location Southern Africa

Length 8–9 in
(20–23 cm)
Weight 2½–2¾ oz
(70–80 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Unlike most waders, the 9 species of coursers live in dry habitats, and get their name from their rapid run. Burchell's courser is sandy brown, with a slight rusty tone (as in the

juvenile pictured), which provides excellent camouflage in the barren country in which it lives. When threatened, the bird stands still and upright to avoid detection, and then runs away very quickly. If forced to, it will fly far and fast. It feeds in a jerky, stop-start manner, taking insects from the ground.

*Vanellus armatus*

Blacksmith lapwing



Location Southern and E. Africa

Length 11–12 in
(28–31 cm)
Weight 4–8 oz
(125–225 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



Widespread in southern and East Africa, this plover is a medium to large wader with very striking black, white, and gray plumage and long, black legs; its eyes are an intense red. Its diet consists of a wide range of invertebrates, frequently taken at night, especially when the moon is bright. Both the male and female are very protective of their young, and will chase or challenge intruders. The blacksmith lapwing gets its name from its sharp, metallic call.

Pluvialis dominica

American golden plover

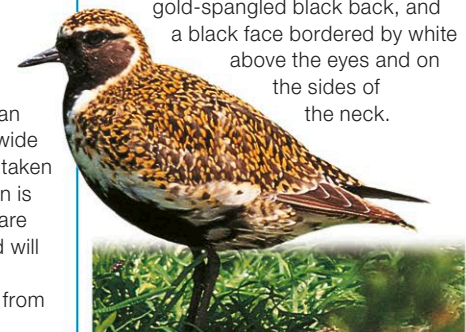


Location N. North America, S. South America

Length 9½–11 in
(24–28 cm)
Weight 4–7 oz
(125–200 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



This medium-sized plover has a remarkable migration pattern, flying northward over land, but southward largely over the sea. It travels very long distances, wintering on coastal marshes and inland grassland in South America and breeding in drier areas of the Arctic tundra. Although mottled brown in winter, it has beautiful breeding plumage—a gold-spangled black back, and a black face bordered by white above the eyes and on the sides of the neck.

*Stiltia isabella*

Australian pratincole



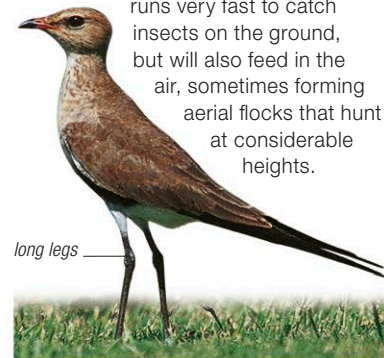
Location S.E. Asia, Australia

Length 8½–9½ in
(21–24 cm)
Weight 2½–2¾ oz
(60–70 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



This Australian bird is an exception among the 8 species of pratincoles in having long legs and unusually long wings. It is pale cinnamon-brown

above and pale tan underneath except for a large, dark chestnut patch on the belly. Its downcurved bill has a red base and black tip. The Australian pratincole runs very fast to catch insects on the ground, but will also feed in the air, sometimes forming aerial flocks that hunt at considerable heights.



long legs

Charadrius hiaticula

Common ringed plover



Location N. North America, Greenland, Europe, Asia, Africa, Madagascar

Length 7–8 in
(18–20 cm)
Weight 1¾–2½ oz
(50–70 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



A short bill, a white neck collar, and black bands on the head and chest are distinctive features of this compact plover. It breeds over a wide range of habitats, but in winter is found mostly on sandy coasts and inland wetlands. It feeds on a variety of invertebrates, foraging for them at night, especially when the moon is full. Both male and female rear the young and will perform a striking "broken wing" display to lure predators from the nest.



white neck collar

orange-yellow legs

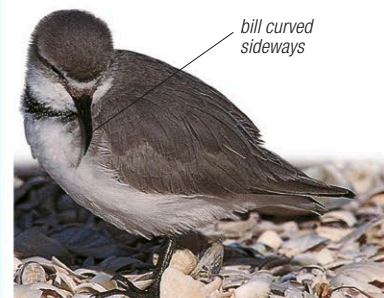
Anarhynchus frontalis

Wrybill



Location New Zealand

Length 8–8½ in
(20–21 cm)
Weight 1¾–2½ oz
(40–70 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Vulnerable



bill curved sideways

The wrybill is the only bird whose bill has a sideways curve. From the side, its bill looks relatively normal—if slightly long for a plover—but when seen from above or head-on, its unusual shape is very evident. The sideways curve is useful when feeding on gravel beaches, allowing the plover to flick stones aside as it hunts for insects and worms. The plumage is soft gray above, and white below, with a narrow, black breastband, more strongly defined in males than in females.

Numenius arquata

Eurasian curlew



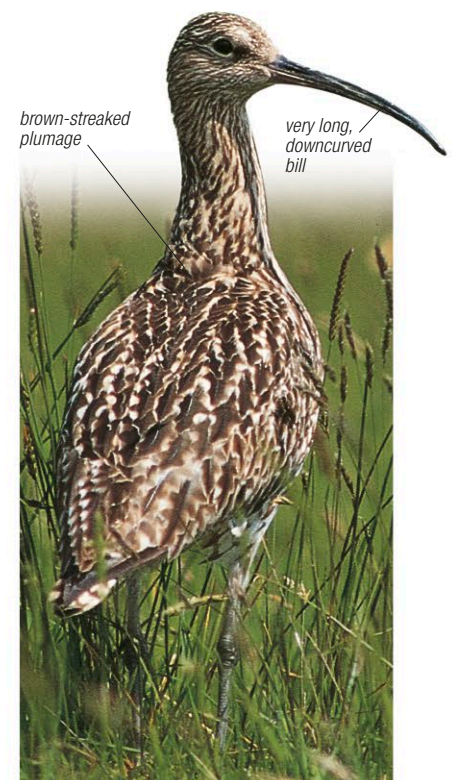
Location Europe, Asia, Africa

Length 20–23½ in
(50–60 cm)
Weight 16–48 oz
(450–1,350 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Near threatened



Famous for its beautiful rising call, the Eurasian curlew is a large, brown-streaked wader with an extremely long, downward-curving bill. Up to 7½ in (19 cm) long, the bill is ideal for extracting animals buried deep in mud or sand. Inland, the bird eats mostly insects and earthworms; on the coast, it feeds on a wide range of worms, shellfish, and crustaceans, especially shrimps and crabs (which the bird usually swallows whole, after removing the legs). It breeds in a variety of habitats, from sand dunes, bogs, and fens to upland heaths and grassland, and becomes strongly territorial at this time. Both male and female defend their territory with a distinctive undulating flight, planing on wings held in a shallow "V" while giving a whistled, bubbling call. Some males will even come to blows with their wings. The Eurasian curlew is one of 8 related species that are found in different parts of the world. They

gather in very large flocks for roosting, but feed in smaller groups. Most are strongly migratory—this particular species breeds as far north as the Arctic Circle, but overwinters in sandy and muddy estuaries from Western Europe to East Asia. It is a long-lived bird that can survive for up to 37 years.



brown-streaked plumage

very long, downcurved bill